

This guide takes the finished website file (`index.html`) and turns it into a live site at **abshurelawncare.com**. Follow the parts in order. Everything here is free except the domain name.

| What you need                                                 | Why                                                                                    |
|---------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| The <code>index.html</code> file                              | This is the whole website. Keep a copy on your computer.                               |
| An email address for the business (abshurelawncare@gmail.com) | Use it for every account below so the business owns them, not whoever helps set it up. |
| About an hour, plus some waiting                              | Domain and security settings can take up to 24 hours to finish on their own.           |
| A payment card (only if you need to buy the domain)           | A .com usually costs around \$10 to \$11 a year.                                       |

## The order of things

- 1 Make a GitHub account and a place (a repository) to keep the site.
- 2 Upload the site and turn on GitHub Pages, which hosts it for free.
- 3 Point the domain at it, buying it through Cloudflare if needed.
- 4 Connect the free-estimate form so requests land in your email.
- 5 Add photos, and later reviews.
- 6 Finish up: Google Business Profile, testing, and upkeep.

### Note

In this guide, **USERNAME** means the GitHub username you pick in Part 1. Replace it with the real one everywhere you see it.

## PART 1

# Make a GitHub account and repository

A repository (repo) is a folder on GitHub that holds the website files.

- 1 Go to **github.com** and choose **Sign up**. Use the business email. Pick a username you're happy to see in links, such as `abshurelawncare`.
- 2 Verify the email address when GitHub sends the code.
- 3 Once signed in, click the **+** in the top-right corner and choose **New repository**.

- 4 For **Repository name**, type `abshurelawncare`.
- 5 Leave it set to **Public**. Free GitHub Pages only works with public repositories, and the photo feature needs it too.
- 6 Click **Create repository**.

#### Tip

If someone else will help maintain the site, add them instead of sharing the password: repo **Settings > Collaborators > Add people**.

## PART 2

# Upload the site and turn on GitHub Pages

## Upload the file

- 1 On the new, empty repository page, click the link **uploading an existing file**. (Later, the same thing is under **Add file > Upload files**.)
- 2 Drag `index.html` onto the page. The file must be named exactly `index.html`, all lowercase.
- 3 Scroll down and click **Commit changes**. Commit just means save.

## Turn on GitHub Pages

- 1 In the repository, click **Settings** (top bar), then **Pages** in the left sidebar.
- 2 Under **Build and deployment**, set **Source** to **Deploy from a branch**.
- 3 Under **Branch**, choose `main` and the `/ (root)` folder, then click **Save**.
- 4 Wait a minute or two and refresh. The page shows **Your site is live at** followed by a link like `https://USERNAME.github.io/abshurelawncare/`. Open it to check the site works.

## PART 3

# Connect the domain (abshurelawncare.com)

## 3A. Find out who owns the domain

The business card already lists `abshurelawncare.com`, so this matters before the cards are printed.

- **If he bought it before:** look for a receipt or renewal email from a company like GoDaddy, Namecheap, Squarespace or Google. Skip to 3C and add the records at that company instead of Cloudflare.
- **If nobody is sure:** search for it at Cloudflare (step 3B). If Cloudflare says it's **available**, he doesn't own it yet, so buy it.
- **If it's taken and it isn't his:** pick a different name (for example `abshurelawn.com`) and update the card and the site before printing.

### 3B. Buy the domain through Cloudflare

Cloudflare sells domains at the price the registry charges, with no markup, and includes DNS (the address book that points the name at the site) for free.

- 1 Go to **dash.cloudflare.com** and sign up with the business email.
- 2 In the dashboard, open **Domain Registration > Register Domains**.
- 3 Search for `abshurelawncare.com` and click **Purchase** next to it.
- 4 Choose 1 year (or more) in **Payment option**, fill in the contact details, and add a payment card.
- 5 Read the agreements and click **Complete purchase**. A confirmation email follows.

#### Important

Auto-renew is on by default. Leave it on and keep a working card on file. If the domain lapses, the site and the web address printed on the card stop working.

### 3C. Add the DNS records

In Cloudflare, click the domain, then **DNS > Records**. First delete any existing **A**, **AAAA** or **CNAME** records named `@` (the bare domain) or `www`, such as parking-page records. Then click **Add record** for each row below:

| Type  | Name | Content / Target   | Proxy status          |
|-------|------|--------------------|-----------------------|
| A     | @    | 185.199.108.153    | DNS only (gray cloud) |
| A     | @    | 185.199.109.153    | DNS only (gray cloud) |
| A     | @    | 185.199.110.153    | DNS only (gray cloud) |
| A     | @    | 185.199.111.153    | DNS only (gray cloud) |
| CNAME | www  | USERNAME.github.io | DNS only (gray cloud) |

#### Two things that trip people up

Set every record to **DNS only** by clicking the orange cloud so it turns gray. GitHub has to reach the site directly to set up its free security certificate (the padlock). If the cloud is orange, the padlock step in 3D tends to get stuck.

The `www` target is just `USERNAME.github.io`. Don't add the repository name to it.

### 3D. Tell GitHub about the domain

- 1 Back in the GitHub repository, go to **Settings > Pages**.
- 2 Under **Custom domain**, type `abshurelawncare.com` and click **Save**. GitHub checks the DNS records. This can take from a few minutes up to 24 hours.

- 3 Once the check passes, tick **Enforce HTTPS**. If the box is grayed out, wait. It can take up to 24 hours to become available.
- 4 Test both `abshurelawncare.com` and `www.abshurelawncare.com`. GitHub sends `www` visitors to the main address automatically.

### Extra protection

Optional but recommended: verify the domain so nobody else can ever attach it to their GitHub site. Click your profile picture > **Settings** > **Pages** > **Add a domain**, then add the **TXT** record GitHub shows you in Cloudflare's DNS records and click **Verify**.

## PART 4

# Make the free-estimate form send emails

The site is just a file, so it needs a free helper service to email form requests. Until this is done, the form shows visitors their details and asks them to call or email instead.

- 1 Go to **formspree.io** and sign up with `abshurelawncare@gmail.com`. Confirm the email address when Formspree asks.
- 2 Create a new form and name it something like **Free estimate**. Have it send to the business email.
- 3 Copy the form's endpoint. It looks like `https://formspree.io/f/abcd1234`.
- 4 In GitHub, open `index.html` and click the **pencil icon** (Edit) at the top right of the file.
- 5 Find the settings section near the bottom (press Ctrl+F, or Cmd+F on a Mac, and search for `formEndpoint`). Paste the endpoint between the quotes:

```
formEndpoint: "https://formspree.io/f/abcd1234",
```

- 6 Click **Commit changes**. The live site updates in a minute or two.
- 7 Test it: fill out the form on the live site. The page should say **REQUEST SENT**, and an email should arrive. Check the spam folder the first time and mark it **Not spam**.

### Free plan limits

The free plan covers 50 requests a month and doesn't accept file uploads, which is why the form has no photo upload. That's plenty for a small business. If it ever runs out, Formspree emails a warning.

## PART 5

# Add photos of his work

Until real photos are added, the gallery shows "Photo coming soon" tiles. Any photo tapped on the site opens up close on the same page.

## One-time setup: turn on automatic photos

Edit `index.html` the same way as in Part 4, find `githubRepo`, and put in the username and repository name:

```
githubRepo: "USERNAME/abshurelawncare",
```

Commit the change. From now on, any picture uploaded to the repository appears on the site by itself. Photos go right next to `index.html`. No folders needed.

## Adding photos

- 1 Open the repository's main page (the same page where `index.html` is listed).
- 2 Click **Add file > Upload files** and drag the photos onto the page. Several at once is fine.
- 3 Click **Commit changes**. Refresh the site after a minute or two.

To remove a photo, click it in the file list, use the ... menu to choose **Delete file**, and commit.

### Keep in mind

Every picture file in the repository shows up in the gallery, so don't upload logos, screenshots or other images there. Only job photos.

| Photo tip                                                                                        | Why                                                                                                                                   |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Name files the way the caption should read, with dashes: <code>front-yard-cabot-after.jpg</code> | The file name becomes the caption: "Front yard cabot after".                                                                          |
| Photos show in alphabetical order by file name.                                                  | Name before-and-after pairs so they sit together, e.g. <code>smith-yard-1-before.jpg</code> and <code>smith-yard-2-after.jpg</code> . |
| Use JPG, PNG or WEBP, taken sideways (landscape).                                                | Landscape fills the tiles best. Other file types are ignored.                                                                         |
| Keep each photo under about 2 MB.                                                                | Big phone photos make the page slow. Most phones can share a smaller size, or use a free resizer.                                     |
| Only post yards with the owner's OK.                                                             | Avoid house numbers, faces and license plates.                                                                                        |

### Other option

Prefer to write captions by hand? Leave `githubRepo` empty and list each photo in `photos` instead, one line each:

```
{ src: "front-yard.jpg", caption: "Front yard, Cabot" },
```

## PART 6

# Add customer reviews

The Reviews section stays hidden until reviews are added, so the site never shows an empty box. Edit `index.html`, find `reviews`, and add one line per review between the square brackets:

```
reviews: [  
  { name: "Jane D.", town: "Cabot", text: "Showed up on time and the yard looks great." },  
],
```

Only use real reviews, with the customer's permission. A first name and last initial is enough. Copying a few good Google reviews here works well.

## PART 7

# Finish up

## Google Business Profile

His Google listing ("Abshure Lawn Care") is what most people see first. Sign in to it at [business.google.com](https://business.google.com) and:

- **Fix the phone number.** It currently shows (501) 259-5905. Change it to **501-259-5388** to match the card and website.
- **Add the website** ([abshurelawncare.com](https://abshurelawncare.com)) once it's live.
- **Add photos** of real jobs. The same photos can go on the website.
- **Ask happy customers for reviews** using the profile's share-review link. Text it to them right after a job.

## Test checklist

Do this on a phone, since that's how most customers will visit:

- The site opens at [abshurelawncare.com](https://abshurelawncare.com) with the padlock showing in the address bar.
- Tapping **Call** opens the phone dialer with 501-259-5388.
- A test estimate request arrives in the business inbox.
- Photos open up close, and swiping moves between them.
- The hours (Monday to Saturday, 7 AM to 7 PM, closed Sunday) and service area are right.

### Before printing the business cards

The card lists [abshurelawncare.com](https://abshurelawncare.com). Get the site live before ordering cards, or take the web address off the card.

## Changing text later

Any wording, the hours, or the service list can be changed the same way: open `index.html`, click the pencil, use Ctrl+F to find the text, edit it, and commit. Change only the words between quotes or tags. If something breaks, open the file's **History** in GitHub to see and undo the last change.

## Ongoing upkeep

- Keep a working card on Cloudflare so the domain renews every year.
- GitHub Pages hosting is free with no renewal needed.
- Check the spam folder now and then for estimate requests.
- Add new photos every few weeks during the season. Fresh work builds trust.

## If something goes wrong

| Problem                                         | Fix                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|-------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Site shows a 404 page                           | Wait a few minutes after turning on Pages. Make sure the file is named <code>index.html</code> and sits at the top of the repository, not inside a folder.                                                             |
| Custom domain says the DNS check failed         | Wait up to 24 hours. Double-check the four A records and the www CNAME, and that each cloud is gray (DNS only).                                                                                                        |
| Enforce HTTPS is grayed out                     | Normal at first. It can take up to 24 hours after the DNS check passes.                                                                                                                                                |
| Form says REQUEST READY instead of REQUEST SENT | <code>formEndpoint</code> is empty or has a typo. It must be inside quotes and end with a comma.                                                                                                                       |
| Photos don't show up                            | Check that <code>githubRepo</code> matches the username and repo exactly, the photos are uploaded next to <code>index.html</code> (not inside a folder), and the repo is public. Wait a couple of minutes and refresh. |
| A photo tile says "Image not found"             | The file name in the list doesn't match the uploaded file. Names are case-sensitive: <code>Yard.JPG</code> is not <code>yard.jpg</code> .                                                                              |